

Chapter 67: Traditional Assamese Food Culture and Environmental Sustainability: An Analytical Study of Bihu Songs

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Abstract

Traditional food culture reflects the knowledge, customs, and practices that communities have developed over generations in relation to food production, preparation, preservation, and consumption. In Assam, this heritage is closely connected to the region's biodiversity and agricultural way of life. This study examines how Assamese Bihu songs represent traditional food culture and promote environmental sustainability. Using a qualitative descriptive approach, it analyses references to indigenous foods, seasonal farming, ecological knowledge, and biodiversity. The findings show that these songs preserve valuable knowledge about sustainable food systems, responsible use of natural resources, and biodiversity conservation. They also offer insights that remain relevant for addressing present-day environmental concerns. Preserving Bihu songs can therefore strengthen cultural heritage while supporting environmental education and sustainable development in Northeast India.

Keywords: Food Culture, Bihu Songs, Environmental Sustainability, Sustainable Food Systems, Northeast India.

1. Introduction

Traditional food culture represents the collective knowledge, practices, beliefs, and customs associated with the production, preparation, consumption, and preservation of food within a community. In Assam, food culture has evolved through centuries of close interaction between people and their natural environment. The fertile plains of the Brahmaputra Valley, extensive wetlands, forests, and diverse agro-ecological landscapes have contributed to a rich food heritage that includes indigenous rice varieties, fish, bamboo shoots, leafy vegetables, wild edible plants, herbs, fruits, and fermented foods. These food practices not only satisfy nutritional needs but also reflect the ecological wisdom of Assamese society.

Bihu, the most celebrated folk festival of Assam, is intrinsically linked with agriculture, seasonal changes, and rural life. The three major Bihus—Rongali (Bohag), Bhogali (Magh), and Kongali (Kati)—mark different phases of the agricultural cycle and embody the harmonious relationship between humans and nature. Assamese Bihu songs (Bihu Naam), transmitted orally across generations, vividly portray the cultural, social, and ecological life of the Assamese people. Besides expressing love, joy, and celebration, these songs frequently refer to indigenous food items, agricultural practices, domestic animals, birds, rivers, forests, seasonal crops, and natural resources.

The references to food in Bihu songs reveal valuable traditional ecological knowledge (TEK), reflecting sustainable practices of cultivation, harvesting, fishing, livestock management, and resource utilization. Such knowledge has become increasingly significant in the contemporary context of biodiversity loss, climate change, environmental degradation, and the erosion of indigenous food systems due to rapid modernization and globalization.

Environmental sustainability emphasizes the responsible use and conservation of natural resources to ensure ecological balance and meet the needs of present and future generations. Traditional food systems often embody principles of sustainability through the use of locally available resources, seasonal consumption, biodiversity conservation, and environmentally friendly agricultural practices. In this context, Assamese Bihu songs serve not merely as cultural expressions but also as repositories of ecological knowledge and environmental ethics.

This chapter seeks to examine how traditional food culture, as reflected in Assamese Bihu songs, contributes to environmental sustainability. It explores the relationship between food traditions, biodiversity, indigenous ecological knowledge, and sustainable living, highlighting the importance of preserving both cultural heritage and ecological resources for the future.

2. Importance and Significance of the Study

This study examines the relationship between traditional food culture, Assamese Bihu songs, biodiversity, and environmental sustainability. While Bihu songs have been extensively studied from literary and cultural perspectives, their ecological significance and indigenous food knowledge have received limited attention. The traditional food practices reflected in these songs promote sustainable agriculture, biodiversity conservation, and responsible use of natural resources. In the context of climate change and the erosion of indigenous knowledge, the study aligns with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). It also contributes to interdisciplinary research and provides valuable insights for environmental education, policy formulation, biodiversity conservation, and sustainable rural development.

2.1. Objectives of the Study

1. The study aims to achieve the following objectives:
2. To identify the traditional food items mentioned in Assamese Bihu songs.
3. To examine the relationship between traditional food culture and the natural environment reflected in Bihu songs.
4. To analyze the traditional ecological knowledge embedded in Assamese Bihu songs.
5. To explore the role of indigenous food practices in promoting biodiversity conservation.
6. To examine the contribution of traditional food culture toward environmental sustainability in Assam.
7. To assess the relevance of traditional food knowledge for contemporary sustainable development and environmental conservation.

8. To highlight the importance of preserving Assamese Bihu songs as repositories of indigenous ecological knowledge and cultural heritage.

2.2. Scope of the Study

The scope of this study is confined to examining traditional food culture as reflected in selected Assamese Bihu songs and analyzing its relevance to environmental sustainability. The study is limited to Assamese Bihu songs collected from published anthologies, folklore collections, scholarly works, and authentic secondary sources. It does not attempt a comprehensive ethnographic survey of all food traditions in Assam or cover all genres of Assamese folk songs. Rather, it focuses specifically on the ecological and environmental significance of food-related references found in Bihu songs.

3. Methodology of the Study

The study adopts a **qualitative, descriptive, and analytical research methodology**.

3.1. Research Design

The research is based on textual analysis of Assamese Bihu songs with an interdisciplinary approach combining folklore studies, environmental studies, and ethnobiology.

Sources of Data

Primary Sources

- Selected Assamese Bihu songs collected from published compilations.
- Authentic collections of traditional Bihu lyrics.
- Folk literature documenting Assamese oral traditions.

Secondary Sources

- Books on Assamese folklore and Bihu culture.
- Research articles and journals related to food culture, biodiversity, and environmental sustainability.

4. Analysis

The main crop of Assam and the Assamese society is paddy. After the rice is harvested, the rice is used to make *pitha-pana*, *muri*, *hurum*, *sandah*, *pithaguri* etc. Similarly, rice is used to make *akhai*, *chira* etc. There are many different types of Bihu songs that are used to describe these dishes. This is discussed below:

The sound of the 'Dheki' is echoing in the neighborhoods of the village almost 7-8 days before Rangali Bihu. After preparing *chira*, *muri*, *sandah*, *hurum* etc., the preparations for Bihu are completed by preparing *ghila pitha*, *til pitha* etc. on the day before *Uruka*.

After all the arrangements are made, the housewife is ready to give to the guests, so that they do not have to be sent back the guest empty-handed during the Bihu days. This aspect of Assamese society is expressed through Bihunam as follows:

'*hurum saandoh sira korai dowo voja*

tekelit malangil doi,

til ghila sutuli choonga-pitha luthuri

thako moi agote loi

After grinding, the *chira* is fried in the rice shell to be placed in the pot. However, nowadays, the prevalence of *chira* crushed in a pot or *fried chira* in a pot has decreased in the villages. In other words, it is rare to hear the sound of the 'Dheng Kuluch Dheng Kuluch' during the *Dhekishal* and Bihu. Anyway, after grinding the *chira*, it tastes great to eat the *dowa bhoja chira* with a bowl of red tea immediately.

'*lutor shuwani majuli chapori*

sargor shuwani tora,

konto sitere amake eri thoi

khali dowo voja sira '

After the arrangement, the guests are treated to *pitha-pana*, *chira*, *sandah* etc. However, the prevalence of *Chotal Bihu* is gradually decreasing. Let us take our context that this society is also treated to *Bihu pitha-pana*. There are many ways in which you can forget about this treatment.

'*ujai bure dile hihu ki ghoriale*

bhatiyai burile mase,

ladu pitha-pona kaloino rakhisa

jadihe bhitorot aase'

When the host does not see the *pitha-pona* brought out despite such reminders,

Then the Bihu group is jealous through the Bihu songs as follows —

'*bihur pitha-pona sira doi hurum oi*

kaloino thoicha hachi,

ratio puwab bihuo vagib

jame ghoraghor gusi'

This is the first time I've seen a guy with a smile on his face. After preparing the chira-pitha etc. for Bihu, you are waiting for the man of your heart.

*'bokul boradhanor sira khundisilo
poguwa gakhiror doi,
tumaloie buli bate chai aasilo
hatot sirar bati loi'*

Underlining this aspect, it can be said again that the cook does not or cannot eat the rice herself without cooking it and feeding her husband and others. The beloved does not wish to eat the food she has prepared without the beloved eating it. This aspect is also expressed through the Bihu songs as follows:

*'bokul boradhanor akhoi bhajisilo
bokona ma'hore doi,
tumi je noh'le khaboke nuwaron
thako moi agote loi'*

When the expected guest does not arrive at the end of the waiting, it is natural to feel sad and also to see the disturbance of the things that have been given to him.

*'tumaloie buli khundo pithagudi
poruwa piporai ki,
chab dia gakhiror molan porile
sondakol marahi jay'*

There are many different types of food including *pitha-pana* and *chira-sandah*, which are essential elements of the Bihu culture of Assam. Rice is the staple food of Assam and the Assamese society. They are also served with a variety of agricultural vegetable soups and home grown vegetables as well as fish and meat. Therefore, this aspect of the diet of the Assamese society cannot be excluded from the discussion. Therefore, this aspect is highlighted below:

*'chokola tengati okole nakhaba
amako esokol dibaa,
noltenga dhekiya nar mas khutora
datot tel lagaai khaba'*

There are also many different types of vegetables available in Bihu songs.

*'ma'ighulir bet-gaj sapekhatir senimas
baligawor babori shaak,
ou tenga tengesi kino khai jaba oi
ka'le or nopore tak'*

There are many ways to get away from these things, but the most important thing is to get away from these things. This taste is also mentioned in the Bihu songs as follows:

*'dibrugaror bengena keji sari ona
telat bhaji khaboloi bhal,
aajikali la'rabor beteree mukhiya
sarih peribor bhal'*

There is no need to repeat the rice and fish dishes cooked with Outenga and naltengga, but the water comes from the tongue explains the dish. These are very tasty but the dried watermelons taste bitter. Therefore, only old or ripe watermelons are suitable for consumption. There are also mentions in Bihu naams as follows:

*'ou kumaliya khaboke nuwari
titiki titiki lage,
mon kumaliya bujabo nuwari
ucupi ucupi kande'*

Like naltengga, autenga etc., kharichha tengga made from bamboo carrots is also popular in Assamese food culture. They are reflected in society and culture. Bamboo carrots are crushed in a pot, put in a clay pot, covered with palm leaves and removed after three to four days. After making kharichha, it is eaten with oil and spices or cooked with porridge. This aspect is expressed through the Bihu songs as follows:

*'jakoi bai aanilo solsolu puthimas
khorisa tenga di randho,
khabore समयত তুলি মানত পূৰে
bhatot patot bohi kando'*

In short, the puthimas cooked with kharichha spicy are as tasty to eat as the pavo fish cooked with kharichha spicy.

*'digholi bojaror pavo mas kini ni
khorisa tenga di randho
khabore সময়ত তুলি মানত পূৰে
bhatot patot bohi kando'*

After cooking the fish caught by the jakoi As a housewife sits on a plate of rice and cries when she remembers her husband, in that way After buying pavo fish from the market and cooking it with spices husband is also crying. When he remembers his housewife. This is a universal picture of Assamese society. Like the pavo fish, the ari and baraley fish dish with lychee is no less delicious. There are also examples of this in the Bihu songs as follows:

'masor bachi la'lu aanrikoi borali

shaakor bachi la'lu lai,
tumak pame buli bate saye r'lu
joubonti bhatiyai jay'

There are many different types of eggplant mashed potatoes in the country. These are the most popular dishes in the country. This aspect of the food of the Assamese society is also reflected in the Bihu naams as follows:

'kochutenga dhekiya bilahee bengena
juti lagaai lagaai khaba,
ratire ratito duwar dang khuli r'ma
birali jowadi jaba'

Similarly, peach soup is another specialty of the Assamese society. When we were young, we expressed it in one word 'small banana plant to eat'—'peach' There are many different types of bananas or peaches cut from the garden. There are many ways to get rid of these peppers. Then this dish helps to kill stomach parasites. Peach soup needs spices to enhance the flavor and boiled soup is even tastier. There are also examples of cooking peaches using this spice in Assamese society as follows:

'barire posola bare di mosola
mare marisile tel,
tumak aanim buli borghor sajilo
bapere chopale mel'

In addition to eating fish soup with spices, fish caught from the fields is roasted, served with leaves or served with charcoal. This is another characteristic of the food of the Assamese society. It's funny, this aspect is preserved in the melody as follows:

'bahbarir agote puthimas kamale
dhor i aani khorikat dio,
eijoni nasoni borokoi barise
dhor i aani phatekot dio'

Like fish, meat is not less tasty in Assamese society. There are many ways to enjoy the taste of duck cooked with cucumbers (*kumura*). with dry rice. This is also the taste of this dish of rice with duck meat

'jahakoi saulor bhatore lagate
hahor mongoh pale khaam,
bhal dora paboloi mooror suli singi
aashirbad di thoi jam'

There are many different types of rice, but the most common type is the rice of the Assamese people. There are many ways to eat rice with salt, oil, raw onion, pepper and mashed fish. However, if you eat lettuce in the summer, the stomach cramps disappear. This is also exemplified in Bihunam —

'habiloi goisilo leteku khaisilo
tolpetot lagile bhok,
ghorloi ahilo poita bhat khaisilo
pete shaal marile mok'

So, it can be seen that the eating habits of the Assamese society are really diverse. There are many different types of Bihu dishes such as *chira*, *pitha*, *sandah*, *akhai*, *hurum* etc. as well as spinach, coconut milk, *khutura*, peaches, *cane- bamboo carrots* etc. There are many ways to cook these dishes, but the most important thing is to cook them with salt and pepper. The saying '*khar khua asamiya*' testifies to this. There are many different types of fish, such as fish, fried, fried or served with leaves. Moreover, rice is the staple food of the Assamese society. In this regard, it is impossible not to connect a meal of duck rice with cucumbers (*kumura*) with dry rice, a handful of potato rice with fried fish mashed potatoes.

The analysis of Assamese Bihu songs reveals that they are valuable repositories of traditional food culture, reflecting the close relationship between food, nature, and Assamese society. The songs mention diverse indigenous food items such as rice-based delicacies, vegetables, fish, bamboo shoots, fruits, and livestock, highlighting the region's rich biodiversity. They preserve traditional ecological knowledge related to sustainable agriculture, seasonal food practices, food preservation, and responsible resource use. These indigenous food traditions promote biodiversity conservation, environmental sustainability, and community harmony. Despite the impact of modernization, the ecological wisdom embedded in Bihu songs remains highly relevant for sustainable development and environmental conservation in contemporary society.

5. Findings

The findings of the study are as follows:

1. The study identifies a wide range of traditional food items in Assamese Bihu songs, including *pitha*, *chira*, *muri*, *hurum*, *sandah*, *akhai*, *fish*, *duck meat*, *bamboo shoots*, fruits, and indigenous vegetables. These foods reflect the richness of Assamese cuisine and its strong dependence on locally available natural resources.
2. The findings reveal that Assamese traditional food culture is closely linked with agriculture and the natural environment. Bihu songs illustrate how seasonal farming, forests, rivers, wetlands, and home gardens influence food production, demonstrating a harmonious relationship between people and nature.
3. The study shows that Bihu songs preserve valuable traditional ecological knowledge related to rice processing, food preservation, seasonal harvesting, fermented foods, bamboo shoots, medicinal plants, and sustainable cooking practices. This indigenous knowledge has been transmitted through oral traditions across generations.
4. The findings indicate that indigenous Assamese food practices encourage the conservation of local crop varieties, vegetables, fruits, fish, bamboo, and livestock. The use of diverse local resources supports biodiversity conservation and strengthens traditional agricultural systems and ecological balance.

5. The study finds that traditional Assamese food culture promotes environmental sustainability through seasonal consumption, local food production, sustainable harvesting, efficient resource utilization, and community participation. These practices reduce environmental pressure and encourage long-term ecological sustainability.

6. The study concludes that traditional food knowledge remains highly relevant for sustainable development. Indigenous food systems support food security, biodiversity conservation, climate resilience, and sustainable agriculture, making them valuable for environmental conservation and rural development.

7. The study establishes that Assamese Bihu songs preserve traditional food culture, indigenous ecological knowledge, and cultural heritage. Protecting these oral traditions is essential for conserving ecological wisdom, promoting environmental awareness, and passing sustainable practices to future generations while safeguarding Assam's cultural identity.

6. Conclusion

The study concludes that Assamese Bihu songs are valuable repositories of traditional food culture and indigenous ecological knowledge. They preserve information on traditional food items, agricultural practices, biodiversity, and the harmonious relationship between people and nature. The songs reflect sustainable food systems based on locally available resources and seasonal consumption, contributing to biodiversity conservation and environmental sustainability. Despite the challenges posed by modernization and the decline of oral traditions, the ecological wisdom embedded in Bihu songs remains relevant for sustainable development. Therefore, preserving these folk traditions is essential for protecting Assam's cultural heritage and promoting environmental conservation for future generations.

7. Suggestions / Recommendations

Traditional food culture preserved in Assamese Bihu songs should be documented, researched, and promoted through education, digital archiving, and community participation. Efforts should focus on conserving indigenous food resources, biodiversity, and ecological knowledge while encouraging interdisciplinary research and integrating traditional wisdom into sustainable development and environmental conservation initiatives.

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Annexure

Annexure I

Selected Traditional Food Items Mentioned in Assamese Bihu Songs

Food Item	Category	Cultural Significance
Chira	Rice Product	Traditional Bihu breakfast
Muri	Rice Product	Festive food
Hurum	Rice Product	Indigenous snack
Sandah	Rice Product	Bihu delicacy
Pitha	Rice Cake	Symbol of hospitality
Til Pitha	Sweet	Prepared during Bhogali Bihu and Magh Bihu
Ghila Pitha	Rice Cake	Festival food
Akhai	Roasted Rice	Traditional snack
Chunga Pitha	Bamboo-cooked rice cake	Indigenous cooking tradition
Pithaguri	Rice Flour	Used in traditional recipes

Annexure II

Indigenous Food Resources Reflected in Bihu Songs

Food Resource	Ecological Source
Indigenous Rice	Paddy Fields
Bamboo Shoots	Bamboo Forests
Fish	Rivers, Wetlands
Duck	Wetland Farming
Banana Stem (Posola)	Home Gardens
Coconut	Household Gardens
Pumpkin	Agricultural Fields
Brinjal	vegetable
Spinach	Leafy vegetable
Naltenga & Outenga	Indigenous Fruit Trees